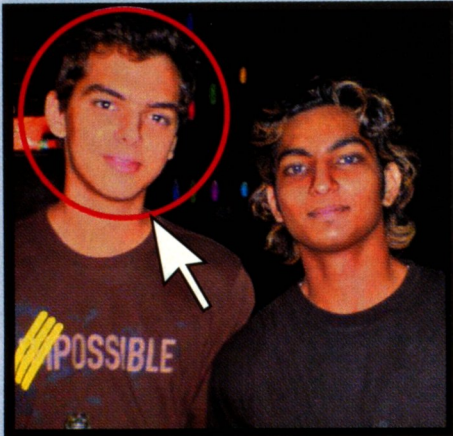


Death in the Fast Lane



The murder of a teenager in Mumbai by his friends who were lured by the lucre of money raises questions about the lifestyle of youngsters, as well as the role of social networking websites in fuelling crime in big cities



VIJAYANAND GUPTA/HT

■ By Prerana Thakurdesai

It's a classic case of too much too soon. For Adnan Patrawala, the 16-year-old boy who was murdered by his friends on August 19 in Mumbai, everything came much before its time—including death. The son of a rich businessman, who spent all his money on his friends, was ironically killed for money by them.

On the night of August 18, Patrawala received a call from his three so-called 'gaming buddies'—Sujith Nair, 28, Ayush Bhatt, 18 and Khimesh Ambavat, 16—asking him to reach Funzone at the Inorbit mall in Malad. Patrawala had met the trio at a gaming centre. Unaware of the kidnapping plot, Patrawala raced his Skoda Octavia to meet his friends. The trio then changed their minds and decided to go for a drive instead. Patrawala informed his mother that he was going out with friends and would

only return in the morning. He drove all over Mumbai the entire night.

The next morning, his friends called his father, a manufacturer of air-conditioning parts, and demanded Rs 2 crore as ransom for the release of his son, who they claimed they had kidnapped. They made him speak to his parents and inform them about his well-being. Before Patrawala's parents could fulfil the kidnappers' demands, news of the incident flashed on television channels. The first-time kidnappers panicked and out of fear of being caught, decided to murder him. They then dumped his body, covered it with shrubs and leaves, in Nerul and returned to their homes the same evening.

The trio was detained and finally arrested on August 20 after they confessed their crime. While Bhatt was picked up from his house in Kandivli, Nair was nabbed at a mall where he had gone to sell his cell

KILLER FRIENDS: Police were swift in arresting the accused (above); Adnan (circled) with Ayush phone. The police have also arrested Rajeev Himmatbhai and are looking for another suspect—Lalla, who they claim were a part of the plot. Meanwhile, Patrawala's family is inconsolable. "The family had decided to pay the extortion money if it was the only way to get their son back. But he was killed before they could even pay up," says a family friend.

Media reports claim the involvement of another person by the name '***Angel***D', whom Patrawala had been in touch with since the past few days, through Orkut. Angel and Patrawala had exchanged a number of messages through the website, over the same period as he had been friends with the trio. They had finally decided to meet on August 18—the day of the murder. The police are now investigating the true identity of Angel and